

other discount brokers that look appealing.

Firsttrade looks good for somebody who wants to invest in mutual funds, but doesn't want to (or can't afford to) sign on with a larger mutual fund company.

There's also the site formerly known as **Zecco.com** and now Ally Invest.

Discount brokers are a good option if you're primarily interested in purchasing individual stocks instead of mutual funds. They're also a fine choice if you want to get started *now*, but can't afford a program with one of the mutual fund companies.

HOW TO OPEN A ROTH IRA

Here's a secret: Opening a Roth IRA is *easy*. Have you ever filled out a job application? Have you ever applied for a credit card? Have you ever opened a bank account? Of course you have. That's exactly what the process is like to start an individual retirement account.

Some firms require that you download the forms and then mail or fax them to the company. Most places, however, provide online applications. Before you begin the application, you will need the following:

1. Your social security number.
2. Your bank account information.
3. Your employment information.
4. Some money. (Depending on where you choose to open your IRA, you may need \$25 or you may need \$3,000.)
5. About an hour of uninterrupted time. (Actually, you probably only need 15 minutes, but allocate more time just to be safe.)

Gather items 1–4 in one location when you're ready to begin. (If you're opening an IRA through a brick-and-mortar bank or broker, take this info with you.) From this point, it's simply a matter of answering simple questions.

Once you've completed the application process, you will be asked to transfer money to your account. This money will probably earn interest in a money market fund until you choose an investment.

I'm a big fan of automatic investment plans. Most of the companies I mentioned earlier in this article offer some sort of program that will pull money from your bank account every month to invest in stocks or mutual funds that you designate. By setting aside \$50 or \$100 or \$500 in this way, saving becomes a habit. You don't notice the money is missing. It's